Task 01

U.S Stock Market Comparative Analysis Report

Goldman Sachs (GS) · NVIDIA (NVDA) · Walmart (WMT)

Period: February 19, 2025 – February 26, 2026 | Data: Yahoo Finance, Morningstar

1. Introduction

This report compares three major U.S. companies: Goldman Sachs Group (GS), NVIDIA Corporation (NVDA), and Walmart Inc. (WMT); spanning financial services, semiconductor technology, and retail. Each represents a distinct corner of the market, and together they illustrate how differently stocks can behave depending on their industry, growth stage, and risk profile. Sources used to get insights and compare the data are Yahoo Finance and Morningstar. The objective is to evaluate each company's price trends, key financial metrics, and recent developments to determine which offers the best risk-return profile for different types of investors. All data is as of February 26, 2026.

2. Price Trend Analysis

Over the past 52 weeks, Goldman Sachs was the standout performer. Starting near $530, GS dipped to a 52-week low of $439 during the April 2025 market selloff triggered by tariff uncertainty, then rallied aggressively to close near $940 gaining nearly 65% for the year. NVIDIA started around $120, hit a painful low of $86 in April, then surged on continued AI demand to reach a high of $212 before settling near $197 by late February 2026, a 43% annual return. Walmart was the calmest of the three, climbing steadily from $104 to a fresh all-time high of $134, driven by consistent sales growth and a booming e-commerce segment, finishing the year up just over 21%.

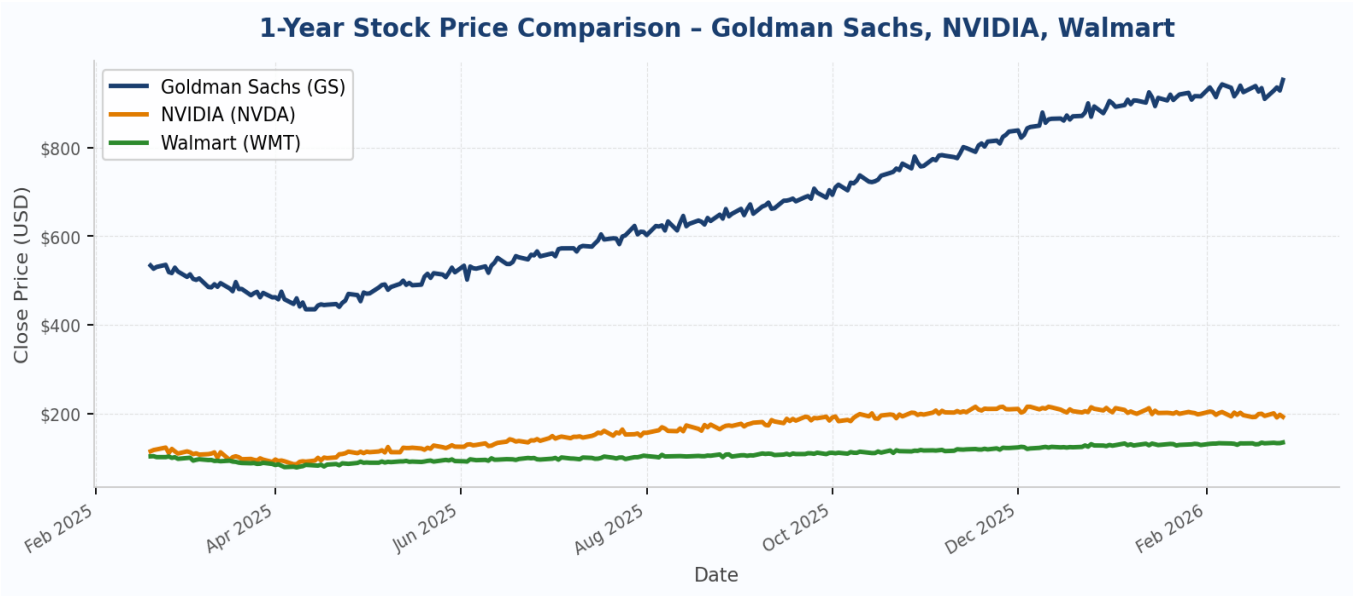

Figure 1: 1-Year Stock Price Comparison of Goldman Sachs, NVIDIA, and Walmart (Feb 2025 – Feb 2026)

Stock	52W Low	52W High	Price Range
Goldman Sachs (GS)	$439.38	$984.70	~124%
NVIDIA (NVDA)	$86.62	$212.19	~145%
Walmart (WMT)	$79.81	$134.69	~69%

3. Key Insights

Goldman Sachs was the top performer. With a 52-week return of +64.67%, GS outperformed the other two stocks by a clear margin. Strong investment banking revenues, record EPS of $49.26, and a 12.5% dividend increase all contributed to its outstanding year.

NVIDIA remains the AI growth story. With a $4.69 trillion market cap and 43% annual return, NVIDIA's Q4 FY2026 results (revenue $68.1B, up 73% YoY) confirmed that AI infrastructure demand shows no signs of slowing. Its beta of 2.31 makes it the riskiest of the three, it was rewarding but volatile.

Walmart is the quiet, reliable performer. With a beta of just 0.67, Walmart barely flinches when markets get nervous. It crossed the trillion-dollar market cap milestone in early 2026 and posted 24% global e-commerce growth in its latest quarter. Its 33-year unbroken dividend streak makes it ideal for conservative, income-focused investors.

4. Performance Indicator Analysis

The table below gives a direct comparison of key financial metrics across all three stocks.

Metric	Goldman Sachs (GS)	NVIDIA (NVDA)	Walmart (WMT)
Market Cap	$277 Billion	$4.69 Trillion	$1.01 Trillion
P/E Ratio	18.89	47.73	44.28
Beta	1.32	2.31	0.67
Dividend Yield	1.70%	0.02%	0.76%
EPS (TTM)	$49.26	$4.04	$2.73
52W High	$984.70	$212.19	$134.69
52W Low	$439.38	$86.62	$79.81
Annual Return	+64.67%	+43.46%	+21.70%

Market Cap & P/E Ratio

NVIDIA's $4.69 trillion market cap dwarfs the other two combined; a reflection of sky-high investor expectations for AI. Its P/E of 47.73 is justified by explosive earnings growth. Goldman Sachs, at a P/E of just 18.89, looks reasonably priced relative to its strong $49.26 EPS. Walmart's P/E of 44.28 is surprisingly high for a retailer, reflecting the premium the market places on its stability and scale.

Beta, Dividend Yield & EPS

Beta tells the risk story: NVIDIA (2.31) swings hard in both directions; GS (1.32) is moderately volatile as expected for a financial firm; and Walmart (0.67) is a near-safe harbor. On dividends, GS leads at 1.70%, while NVIDIA's 0.02% is essentially zero, it reinvests everything. Walmart's 0.76% is modest but decades-reliable. EPS-wise, Goldman Sachs is the clear earnings powerhouse at $49.26 per share.

Annual Return

GS (+64.67%) significantly outperformed the other two over the past year. NVDA (+43.46%) remains exceptional for a company already worth trillion. WMT (+21.70%) is a solid result for a defensive consumer staple.

Comparative Annual Return: Bar Chart

Company	Ticker	Annual Return Performance	Return
Goldman Sachs	GS		**+64.67%**
NVIDIA	NVDA		**+43.46%**
Walmart	WMT		**+21.70%**

5. Recent News

Goldman Sachs (GS)

Goldman Sachs reported full-year 2025 revenue of $59.4 billion, up ~14% year-over-year, driven by recovering deal flow and strong capital markets activity. The bank announced a 12.5% quarterly dividend increase to $4.50 per share. A clear signal of management's confidence in forward earnings. The firm has also been actively building out institutional cryptocurrency trading and custody services. One notable development was general counsel Kathryn Ruemmler's resignation amid scrutiny over historical Epstein ties.

NVIDIA (NVDA)

NVIDIA's Q4 FY2026 earnings (reported Feb 25, 2026) showed revenue of $68.1 billion, a 73% year-over-year increase that beat analyst expectations. The Data Center segment, powered by Blackwell and H200 GPUs, was the primary driver. CEO Jensen Huang reiterated that AI infrastructure demand remains in its early innings. Goldman Sachs maintained a Buy rating with a $250 price target. NVIDIA also announced a multi-year partnership with Meta to support large scale AI infrastructure. The company noted zero revenue from China due to ongoing export restrictions, which remains a key risk factor.

Walmart (WMT)

Walmart's Q4 FY2026 report (Feb 19, 2026) showed revenue of $190.7 billion, with e-commerce up 24% globally and 27% in the U.S. Advertising revenue climbed 46% to $6.4 billion, highlighting the growth of higher-margin businesses beyond retail. The company surpassed $700 billion in annual revenue for the first time in its history. However, FY2027 guidance of 3.5–4.5% sales growth was seen as conservative, causing the stock to pull back slightly. Amazon reportedly surpassed Walmart in total global sales in early 2026 which is a notable retail industry milestone.

6. Conclusion

Each of these three stocks tells a very different story. Goldman Sachs had the best year of the three; strong earnings, dividend growth, and a reasonable valuation make it a compelling choice for investors looking for financial sector exposure without excessive risk. NVIDIA is the most exciting but also the most demanding: if you believe AI infrastructure spending continues to grow for years, NVDA is hard to pass up. But its volatility means it is not for the faint of heart. Walmart is a trillion-dollar retailer that pays a reliable dividend, grows e-commerce at double-digit rates, and holds up well when markets are going a bit down.

In short: Goldman Sachs for value and momentum, NVIDIA for growth and AI exposure, Walmart for stability and income. Together, they represent a well-rounded cross-section of what the U.S. market has to offer heading into the rest of 2026.